

DAY OF THE DOGMATIST

His diktats continue to be the most feared commandments in politics today. As the custodian of a redundant ideology, he never stops inventing enemies.

■ By S. Prasannarajan

An old spectre is haunting Delhi. Abandoned elsewhere in the world by a merciless history, it has taken refuge in a place where there is no Pope or Czar to overcome. Communism, the unravelled lie of the last century, may have lost its original homelands in Russia and eastern Europe. Doesn't matter, there are always theorists in thrall who can argue with such dialectical conviction about the inevitabilities of scientific error in practice. So, there is always a socialist afterlife beyond the detritus of the Soviet empire and the fallen vassal states; there are always projects in the creation of a New Man consonant with specific national characteristics, as in Havana, Hanoi, Beijing, Pyongyang—and, of course, Delhi. There are also revolutionaries armed with the book to guard against the possibility of Marx being exiled to the souvenir shop—or to the nearest McDonald's. Thank God, the revolution of Prakash Karat is bound by the armchair and he is not the gatekeeper of an Indian Gulag that can be the final destination for the running dogs of imperialism and other bad eggs of counter-revolution.

Still, Karat is not the harmless lord of the Brotherhood in Red. The world he surveys from the vantage point of AKG Bhavan on Bhai Vir Singh Marg in Delhi is a world hostile to the revolutionary ideal, and where counter-revolutionary viruses are on the offensive. Comrade General Secretary can't afford to ease his vigil, for enemies—a historical prerequisite for the perpetuation of the dictatorship of the proletariat (or politburo)—are at work. He has identified them, and his diktats against

them are the most decisive commandments in Indian politics today. Nuclear deal with America, no. It is a surrender of national sovereignty to the cannibalistic imperialism of America. The "neo-liberal" economic policies of the UPA Government, again no. They only accelerate the evil of globalisation. Karat has denied Manmohan Singh the moment of a moderniser. And there lies the most abiding paradox of power we can get.

Despite their incompatibility, the unforgiving apparatchik and the apolitical prime minister are mutually indispensable. Neither is moulded by electoral politics: Karat reached his revolutionary adulthood through the class struggle of the campus and Manmohan reached 7 Race Course Road through the antechambers of the technocrat and the holy shrine of the dynasty. Karat has suffered Manmohan's capitalist temptations and his idolisation of the Evil Empire up to a point because of the exigencies of a secular regime in Delhi. It is Karat's ideological responsibility to keep the "communalism" of Hindu nationalism at bay. He wants to rule without being officially in power. He is the Great Leader without his Hermit Kingdom. His powers are not limited by the responsibilities of the office—he enjoys more than the privileges of political harlotry. The dynamics of political co-existence has made the Marxist arbiter second only to the Madonna of 10 Janpath. The persistence of Karat's dogma gave the UPA Government its worst year. His anti-Americanism, which is as pathological as Hugo Chavez's, and which hardly reflects the sentiments of the civil society, has undone a deal the UPA has been hardselling as India's triumph at the high table of global power.

The India of his mind that can accommodate any amount of ideological fossil may still not materialise for the simple reason that Indian communists have never comprehended this country—or won it. The Left's numerical arrogance in Parliament is actually born out of its strength in two states, West Bengal and Kerala. Karat as the honourable upholder of national interest can't conceal the larger failure of communism in coming to terms with the human dimensions of the nation, which is more than a historical abstract. The liberation rite of 1989 showed us that much. The apparatus he presides over has not abandoned the dialectic of the jackboot. The blood in Nandigram has only reaffirmed how CPI(M) has internalised Stalinist horror chambers. Buddhadeb Bhattacharya the McMarxist may have said sorry belatedly; Karat the apparatchik-in-chief remains remorseless. Sentimentalism can't be a Marxist trait, certainly not in comrades who never let their conscience interfere with "incidents" like Tiananmen Square or the crushed Prague Spring—and Karat doesn't aspire to be the Dubcek of the Indian Left.

Communism gave man the freedom to dream. While in power, it denied man his essential humanity. The power of Karat has denied this Government the freedom to play out its golden script of national salvation. He is our newsmaker of the year because his dogma intimidated as well as influenced the nation and his victims almost said "Yes Czar!" ■

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